HOLY TRINITY UNIVERSITY

DEPARETMENT OF DOGMATIC THEOLOGY

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Year 2018

HOLY TRINITY UNIVERSITY

FACULTY OF FUNDMANTAL THEOLOGY

DEPARTMENT OF DOGMATIC THEOLOGY

Instructor: Fikremariam Bazezew

Name of the Course: Veneration and intercession of saints

4th Year

1st Semester

Credit Hour: 3 Credit Hours

Contact Hours: 1:50 min

Medium of Instruction: English, Amharic, Geez languages

Course description;

In the Orthodox Church we invoke and venerate saints. They are an essential part of religious life. In fact, it has been said that warm veneration of the Theotokos and the Saints is the soul of Orthodox piety. We shall devote this chapter to a study of why we honor saints and what role they play in the story of our salvation.

Objective or goal of the course

Students taking this course will be able to

- Understand Orthodox teaching about veneration and intercession of Saints
- Understand why we venerate Saints
- Realize what intercede means
- Differentiate between Orthodox and heterodox teaching based on veneration of Saints

Course content;

The course envelops or covers;

Chapter One

Introduction

Veneration and intercession Saints

Chapter Two

What are a saint's and their categories?

Chapter three

"Called to be Saints"

Chapter Four

The communion of Saints

Chapter Five

Intercession of Saints

Chapter Six

What did the early church scholars writers said regarding prayer to Saints?

Course Approach/Method;

Lecturing/ Discussion

Course assessment;

Mid Exam 30%

Attendance 10%

Final Exam 60%

Main Text

Aspects of Church History. G. Florovsky, Nordland Publishing Co.

Eastern Christendom. N. Zernov, G.P. Putnam and Sons. NY.

Reprinted from Book of Comfort. By Alvin Rogness, copyright 1979. Augsburg Publishing House.

Some Aspects of Contemporary Greek Orthodox Thought. Gavin.

The Orthodox Church. Viking-Penguin Press. New York, NY.

The Spiritual Counsels of Father John of Kronstadt. James Clarke and Company. London.

In Search of True Wisdom. Bolshakoff and Pennington. Doubleday and Company. 1979.

Reference Book

V. Lossky, Panayia in The Orthodox Church in the Ecumenical Movement. W.C.C. Publications.

Interpreting Orthodoxy. N.A. Nissiotis, Light and Life Publishing Company. Minneapolis, MN.

Eastern Christendom. By N. Zernov. G.P. Putnam and Sons. NY. 1961. The Transfiguration of the Body. By K. Ware. An article in Sacrament and Image edited by A.M. Allchin. Fellowship of St. Alban and St. Sergius 1967.

Aspects of Church History. G. Florovsky. Nordland Publishing Company. Belmont, MA.

CHAPTER ONE

1. VENERATION AND INTERCESSION SAINTS

1.1 VENERATION

It is to treat something or someone with reverence, deep respect, and honor. Veneration is distinct from worship (gr. latreia), for worship is a total giving over of the self to be united with God, while veneration is showing delight for what God has done.

1.2 INTERCESSION

That means simply being a middleman. So in prayer it is putting a request to God on behalf someone else. It is important than to understand that we are not worshiping or praying to the saints. Instead we are talking to them asking for them to pray on our behalf.

1.3 WHY WE VENERATE THE SAINTS AND THE THEOTOKOS

In the Orthodox Church we invoke and venerate saints. They are an essential part of religious life. In fact, it has been said that warm veneration of the Theotokos and the Saints is the soul of Orthodox piety. We shall devote this chapter to a study of why we honor saints and what role they play in the story of our salvation.

1,4 THE CELEBRATION OF GOD'S SALVATION

In honoring the saints we celebrate God's accomplished work of salvation. **Archbishop Paul of Finland writes**, "In glorifying the saints' spiritual struggle

and victory, the Church is in fact glorifying God's work of salvation, the work of the Holy Spirit; it experiences the salvation already accomplished in them, the goal towards which the members of the Church militant are still pressing on" (Phil. 3:12,14) Thus, by remembering the saints we celebrate what the Holy Spirit has done in their lives. How greatly God honors our nature through the saints. Father **John of Kronstadt,** a saintly Russian priest, emphasized this when he wrote: How the Creator and Provider of all has honoured and adorned our nature! The saints shine with His light, they are hallowed by His grace, having conquered sin and washed away every impurity of body and spirit; they are glorious with His glory, they are incorruptible through His incorruption. Glory to God, Who has so honoured, enlightened, and exalted our nature.

The saints show us what a glorious destiny we have in God. Through the glorious example of their lives, they point the way to our becoming "partakers of divine nature.

CHAPTER TWO

2. WHAT MEAN SAINT?

Let us share some inspiring definitions of sainthood: A saint is one who makes God's goodness attractive. Saints are forgiven sinners living out their lives in the forgiveness God has given them. Saints are people who make it easier for others to believe in God. A little girl said once as she looked at a saint in a stained glass window: "A saint is a Christian who lets God's light shine through."

St. Symeon the New Theologian says that the reason vigil lights are placed before the icons of the saints is to show that without the Light, Who is Christ, the saints are nothing. It is only as the light of Christ shines on them and through them that they become alive and resplendent. A saint is one who is constantly conscious of being a sinner and rarely, if ever, conscious of being a saint. In fact, it has been said that there are **two kinds of people in the world*: sinners who think they are saints, and saints who know they are sinners.*** The most outstanding personalities in Orthodox spirituality, those who saw the uncreated light of God, never said they had reached that high level of spirituality. The people around them detected it from the distinct radiance they generated. It has been said that when a saint gets to heaven, he will be surprised by three things.

First, he will be surprised to see many he did not think would be there.

Second, he will be surprised that some are not there whom he expected to see. Third, he will be surprised that he himself is there. ***A saint is one who sees himself in the sins of others. A saint is one in whom Christ lives***; one who opens his life to Christ and lives as Christ wills him to live. A saint is one who has been made actually what Baptism declares him to be, one set apart for God. God's saints are not those who wear the biggest halos. They are ordinary people who go to work, pay taxes, talk to friends. But when God speaks, they obey. God's saints are often afraid but they count on God's promise, "Fear not." They know they are weak, but they depend on His strength. They sin, but grieve over every lapse. They never feel they have attained, but constantly press on toward their goal (Phil. 3:14)

The saints show the way and are forerunners. The world is not yet with them, so they often seem in the midst of the world's affairs to be preposterous. Yet they are impregnators of the world, vivifiers and animators of potentialities of goodness which but for them would lie forever dormant (William James, 1842-1910).

Saints are the most convincing answer to atheism and agnosticism. A saint is someone who shows us what the Christian life is really all about.

A saint is a sinner who keeps trying. **Francis R. Line** wrote these words entitled "A Saint?: What made Francis a saint? It was simple. Love of God and love of neighbors.

That was all. He lived the two great commandments. He really loved. He loved God With all his heart,

With all his mind,

With all his soul,

With all his strength.

As for his neighbors– He gave his whole life to them In loving word and deed and service. It is simple, being a saint. There are only two rules. It is simple But it isn't easy.

Saints are people who have consecrated themselves wholly to strive to express in their daily lives the love of God as revealed in Jesus. The Greek word for saint hagios comes from a root word that means not like anything else, different. Saints

are different from the people of the world. They march to the tune of a different drummer. They are conformed to the will of God in Christ. As members of the Body of Christ, the Church, saints are the hands of God by which He accomplishes His work in the world today. Even after their deaths, they perform works of love as intercessors in heaven who pray for us.

A saint is "the aroma of Christ to God among those who are being saved" through whom Christ "spreads the fragrance of the knowledge of Him everywhere" (2 Cor. 2:15-16).

All of us are involved in the process of deification, i.e., becoming like God in Christ. The saints are those who, having advanced closer to that goal, can help the rest of us through their example and prayers.

Francis R. Line has written this beautiful definition of a saint as a mirror of Christ: Francis of Assisi was poor, Frail in purse and body. No excess possessions, No surplus muscles or strength. Plain sandals, rude cloak, rough cowl. Not much to look at. But No one saw him when they looked. They saw the one he reflected. He was a mirror of Christ. ***A saint is a mirror who reflects not himself but Christ.***

2.1 CATEGORIES OF SAINTS

In the Orthodox tradition, the Saints can be generally classified in the following categories:

The Angles, who pries every day before God.

The Apostles, who were the first ones to preach the Incarnation of the Word of God and of salvation through Christ.

The Prophets, who prophesied the coming of our Lord, Jesus Christ.

The Martyrs who sacrificed their lives and fearlessly confessed Jesus Christ as God and Savior.

The Fathers and Hierarchs of the Church, who excelled in explaining and defending the faith, by word and deed.

The Monastics, who lived in seclusion, dedicating themselves to spiritual exercise (*askesis*), and reaching, as far as possible, perfection in Christ.

The Just or Righteous, who lived in the world, leading exemplary lives in Christ as clergy or laity.

Chapter three

CHAPTER THREE

3. "CALLED TO BE SAINTS"

St. Paul wrote to the Romans: "To all God's beloved in Rome, who are called to be saints…." (Romans 1:7). To the Corinthians he wrote: "To the Church of God which is at Corinth, to those sanctified in Jesus Christ, called to be saints…" (1 Cor. 1:2). When Paul was writing to the Christians in Rome and Corinth, reminding them that they are "called to be saints", he was not writing to people likely to figure in stained-glass windows, but to a motley collection of shop-keepers, minor civil servants, converted prostitutes, prizefighters and slaves. These were the people he called God's "holy ones"–called to be like Christ their Lord, agents and instruments

of His continuing work in the world. These were the "saints". And so, by God's grace, are we.

Every Christian is called to perfection and is capable of revealing the image of God hidden in him. But only a few become so transfigured through the Holy Spirit during their earthly life that they can be recognized as saints by other Christians and officially canonized as such by the Church. This should not draw our attention away from the fact that every baptized Christian is called to be a saint. In the New Testament the saints were not a spiritual elite but the whole body of Christians. That never meant that all Christians were regarded as having reached a sinless perfection. In that sense there are no saints in the New Testament, for even the best of Christians are far from perfect. The only saints the New Testament knows are forgiven sinners who are always ready to place their utter dependence on God's mercy and grace.

Maximos the Confessor writes that the Saints are men and women who have reached theosis; they have avoided sin, and tried to live according to created nature, thus achieving total unity with God through the Holy Spirit (On Theology, 7.73). They fought the *"good fight for the faith"* (1 Tim. 6:12 and 2 Tim. 4:7), and applied the scriptural virtues of *"justice, piety, fidelity, love, fortitude, and gentleness"* (1 Tim. 6:11) in their lives.

Thus, there are the Saints, with a capital "S", those officially recognized and canonized by the Church, and there are the saints with a small "s", who are the whole body of Christians–you and I included. We, too, are called to be men and

women in whom others can in some way meet the living Christ. We can appreciate our call to be saints when we realize that saints become saints not so much because of the unusual things they do but rather because of the unusual degree to which they give themselves to Christ. By our daily faithfulness to Christ, each of us is a saint in the making. Made in the image of God and baptized in the Trinity, every Christian has the potential of sainthood.

Bp. Kallistos Ware writes, "It must not for one moment be thought that there are no saints except those publicly honoured as such. Those who are mentioned in the calendar form but a small fraction of the whole Communion of Saints; besides them there is a great host whose names are known to God alone, and these are venerated collectively on the Feast of All Saints (observed on the first Sunday after Pentecost)

3.1 FROM EVERY CLASS AND OCCUPATION

Saints come from every class and occupation, every temperament and background. They show us how Christ can be imitated in everyone's life including our own. As we have models in business, science, homemaking, etc., so we have faith models. We have soldier-saints, scholar saints, politician-saints, missionary-saints, parent-saints, praying-saints, healer-saints, worker-saints, and most important of all, sinner-saints. Saints are not perfect people: to be a saint is to be the best one can be by God's grace. That is why every saint is different and why every Christian can be one.

3.2 FULLY HUMAN

The Saints were people who were just as human as we are. They were jealous, spiteful, scheming, lustful, often depressed and utterly discouraged. They did not walk through life with halos gleaming, with kindness and love streaming from them 24 hours a day. There were strong disagreements among them. St. Paul and St. Barnabas, for example, had a strong difference of opinion as to whether to take John Mark along with them on a missionary journey. Their disagreement was strong enough to make them agree to go their separate ways. Writing to the saints at Corinth, St. Paul reminds them that some of them had been fornicators, idolaters, adulterers, thieves, covetous, extortioners…but now in Christ they were washed and sanctified, he tells them. Thanks be to Christ Who washes our soiled humanity and transforms it into an attractive image of Christ that serves as an inspiration to others.

3.3 GOD'S FAMILY

St. Paul wrote to the Ephesians: "So then you are no longer strangers and sojourners, but you are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God…" (Eph. 2:19). Every Christian has status. He or she belongs. We are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God! Christians should be taught from infancy to have the right kind of family pride: the kind that makes us want to live up to the family standard. The Head of our family is Christ Himself. Some of our brothers and sisters are the Theotokos, John the

Baptist, the Apostles, St. Basil, St. Chrysostom and countless others. We belong to them, and they to us. It is a distinguished family tree.

A Christian does not walk alone as if sealed in a space capsule. We are members of God's family. As such, we must help and be helped by others. Orthodox Christianity does not espouse a narrowly individualistic "God-and-me" relationship. The Church is a family, God's family, in which we are concerned for one another. In the words of St. Paul: "If one member suffers, all suffer together; if one member is honored, all rejoice together" (1 Cor. 12:26). The Russian theologian Alexis Khomiakov (1804-60) said, "We know that when one of us falls, he falls alone; but no one is saved alone. He is saved in the Church, as a member of her and in union with all her other members.

As members of the household of God, Orthodox Christians feel that they can call upon their brothers and sisters in the faith-the saints-for family support. This they do through prayers, beseeching the prayers of the saints in their behalf.

The late Fr. George Florovsky, eminent Orthodox theologian, wrote: The final purpose of the Incarnation was that the Incarnate should have a "body" which is the Church…. Christ is never alone. He is always the Head of His Body. In Orthodox theology and devotion alike, Christ is never separated from His Mother, the Theotokos, and His "friends", the Saints. The redeemer and the redeemed belong together inseparably. In the daring phrase of St. John Chrysostom, inspired by Ephesians 1:23, Christ will be complete only when His Body has been completed.

Speaking on the concept of the church as the family and household of God, Nicolas Zernov wrote

The Orthodox…regard the saints…as teachers and friends who pray with them and assist them in their spiritual ascent. Jesus Christ during His earthly ministry was surrounded by disciples who did not prevent others from meeting Him, but on the contrary helped newcomers to find the Master. In the same manner fellowship with the saints facilitates communion with God, for their Christ-like character brings others nearer to the divine source of light and life.

At Yankee Stadium, the home of the New York Yankees, there is a "Yankee Hall of Fame". One can spend a number of hours reading about all the great Yankee stars of the past. By putting on earphones one can hear their voices on recordings, telling among other things what their greatest thrills were as Yankee players. God also has a "Hall of Fame". In Hebrews Chapter 11, He has listed some of the heroes and heroines of faith–men and women who trusted in God for their salvation. It is a thrilling chapter to read. The Saints are in God's "Hall of Fame". They are the heroes of our faith. Carlyle said once, "Show me the man you honor, and I will show you the kind of man you are." It has been said that we are fresh out of heroes for our young people today. We are exalting punks. Saints make excellent heroes for children. They are powerful allies for parents and ideal heroes for children. It is for this reason that an Orthodox Christian is given the name of a saint at Baptism. In fact, the great St. John Chrysostom said,

Let us afford our children from the first an incentive to goodness from the name that we give them. Let none of us hasten to call his children after his forebearers, his father and mother and grandfather and grandmothers, but rather after the righteous-martyrs, bishops, apostles. Let one be called Peter, another John, another bear the name of one of the saints. Let the names of the saints enter our homes through the naming of our children.

It is not only the names but also the exemplary Christ-centered examples of the saints that can enter our homes if parents will encourage children to learn about their patron saints. It is the custom among Orthodox to keep an icon of one's patron saint in one's room, to invoke his or her prayers and to celebrate the festival of one's patron saint as his/her Name Day. To many Orthodox this is a date even more important than one's actual birthday. It is not just children who need heroes; adults also need them. In fact, in the early Church the veneration of saints was not imposed on the people by the hierarchy or the Church Councils. It was a practice that the people themselves began. It was a spontaneous act of the local community. They began to venerate certain exemplary Christians and then petitioned the Church to canonize them. Hero worship is part of human nature. Most of us want someone to look up to and admire. We need role models in our Christian faith. We grow to be like the people we admire. If the desire for holiness is to be encouraged, one must see, not only its perfection in Christ, but approximations to it in the saints. In fact, if we see such holiness only in our Saviour and not in His people (the saints), we may be disposed to consider holiness as an impossible ideal which we imperfect humans can never attain. We learn best when we see concrete examples

of how to live the life of Christ in the world today. This is why the saints are a challenge to us. They can shake us out of our complacency with our mediocre way of following Christ. Each saint shows us some particular aspect of the life of Christ and in imitating them we imitate Christ. Thus, St. Paul could tell his converts, "I urge you, then, be imitators of me" (1 Cor. 4:16)

Looking back to his childhood, a noted author wrote: We grew up with the strength of the tribe. If anyone were to attack me, he'd have to take on all my uncles and aunts. Families were secure…I had bleachers all round me, filled not only with my family, but with all the grown-ups in the township, cheering me on when I did well and groaning when I failed… All sorts of young people today run the race with only silence from the bleachers. It's a lonely race. Grandparents are a thousand miles away, uncles and aunts scattered to both coasts and overseas, parents often busy with double jobs, harried by their own affluence, or casualties of the divorce courts.

3.4 "A CLOUD OF WITNESSES"

The Bible also speaks of bleachers. The author of the book of Hebrews writes, "We are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses" (Hebrews 12:1). The "cloud of witnesses" are the saints who have passed on to the Church Triumphant. They are with us in the stadium as we run the race of life. They fill the bleachers. They applaud us and cheer us on to victory. They pray for us to attain our goal. They have advice to give. For they have run on the very same track and have won the garland of victory. They offer us more than applause and prayers; they offer us

evidence. They can tell us how they ran the race and won, how they trained for it, how they maintained their strength. We are surrounded by these witnesses. The air is thick with them. They are like a cloud in their multitude. The walls of Orthodox churches are filled with them. And every one of them has a story to tell, a story of grace and divine mercy, a story that is full of encouragement for the runners of today, if only we will listen to them. David, Daniel, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Matthew, Mark, Luke, John and millions of others. "We are surrounded by a great cloud of witnesses"–not one of them silent or indifferent; all of them eager to share with us what the Lord did for them, how they found Him, what grace they received. It is because we are "surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses" that we are exhorted to "lay aside every weight and sin which clings so closely" (Hebrews 12:1). It is because we are "surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses" that we are challenged to "run with perseverance the race that is set before us" (Hebrews 12:1). It is because we are "surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses" that we are admonished to look "to Jesus the pioneer and perfecter of our faith" (Hebrews 12:2). The saints are more than just watching us. They are surrounding us with their prayers, their cheers and the challenging stories of their victories in Christ.

We are not alone as we proceed on the journey to the kingdom. We are part of God's great family which includes those who have gone on before us. Just as it makes a difference in the lives of children when the bleachers are filled with uncles, aunts, and grandparents, so it makes a difference when we know that the bleachers of heaven are filled with saints, cheering us on with their prayers and challenging us with the examples of their lives.

CHAPTER FOUR

4. THE COMMUNION OF SAINTS

Although saints are not substitutes for Christ, Orthodox Christians believe firmly in the communion of saints. By this we mean that the Church Triumphant in heaven is not insensitive to the needs and sufferings of the Church Militant on earth. The two churches remain connected through the bond of love which is expressed through prayer. The communion of saints is a communion of never-ending love and prayer.

Thus, besides our church family on earth, we belong to a larger family of God, which includes those who have gone before us. We are united with those in heaven. We call this the Communion of Saints, that is, the union of all who share in the life of Christ, whether on earth or in heaven.

Commenting on this, Bp. Kallistos Ware writes:

In God and in His Church there is no division between the living and the departed, but all are one in the love of the Father. Whether we are alive or whether we are dead, as members of the Church we still belong to the same family and still have a duty to bear one another's burdens. Therefore just as Orthodox Christians here on earth pray for one another and ask for one another's prayers, so they pray for the faithful departed and ask the faithful departed to pray for them. Death cannot sever the bond of mutual love which links the members of the Church together.

Fr. John of Kronstadt writes on the communion of saints: "We live together with them (the saints in heaven), in the house of the Heavenly Father, only in different

parts of it. We live in the earthly, they in the heavenly half; but we can converse with them, and they with us." How effectively the Communion of Saints is expressed on the walls of Orthodox Churches where the angels, prophets, apostles, martyrs and saints are all gathered together with the worshippers around the figure of the All-Ruling Christ in the dome. The entire Church, that in heaven and that on earth, converses with each other and lifts its heart in praise to God. Sergius Bolshakoff caught this when he visited the Monastery of Dionysiou on Mt. Athos. He writes: "The church had its own air of mystery. A few red lamps burned before the golden iconostasis and the icons on the stand. Hieratic saints solemnly looked down from the blue walls. It seemed as though they, too, had come to assist at the Liturgy, representing the church triumphant." Noting the small congregation in church on Sunday morning, a cynic said to the priest, "Not many in church this morning, Father. Not many at all." The old priest replied, "You are wrong, my son. There were thousands at church this morning. Thousands and thousands and tens of thousands." For, the priest had just read in the prayers of the liturgy: "Therefore with angels and archangels and all the company of heaven we laud and magnify thy glorious name, evermore praising Thee…." It was the Communion of Saints in action!

4.1 THE THEOTOKOS

Among all the saints, the Orthodox Church reserves a special position of honor for the Blessed Virgin Mary, who is venerated as the most exalted among God's creatures, "more honorable than the cherubim and incomparably more glorious than the seraphim." The titles given to Mary by the Orthodox Church: Theotokos

(Mother of God), Aeiparthenos (Ever-Virgin), and Panayia (All-Holy) serve a theological purpose. Far from elevating her to a position as a fourth person of the Trinity, such titles seek to protect and proclaim the correct doctrine of Christ's Person. The Mother is venerated because of the Son and never apart from Him. Too often a refusal to honor the Theotokos goes hand in hand with an incomplete faith in the Incarnation, i.e., the mystery of God becoming man in the Person of Jesus. Nicholas Cabasilas has written: The Incarnation was not only the work of the Father, of His Power and His Spirit…but it was also the work of the will and faith of the Virgin… Just as God became incarnate voluntarily, so He wished that His Mother should bear Him freely and with her full consent. Mary stands as the greatest example of man's free response to God's offer of salvation. She stands as an example of synergy, or cooperation between man and God. God does not force His will on Mary but waits for her free response which she grants with those beautiful words: "Behold the handmaid of the Lord; be it done to me according to your word" (Luke 1:38). Thus, Eve's disobedience is counterbalanced by Mary's obedience. She becomes the New Eve as Christ is the New Adam, lifting by her obedience the curse that the first Eve brought upon the human race by her disobedience.

4.2 VENERATION

Orthodox Christians do not worship the Theotokos and the saints; rather they venerate them. God alone is worshipped. Anyone who claims that the Orthodox worship saints is guilty of bearing false witness against his neighbor since we clearly do not believe this. The saints are reverenced as reflections of the Christ

image. It is God Who is glorified through His saints. They are praised for what God has done in and through them. Reverence for saints is enhanced through the use and veneration of icons which are ever present in Orthodox homes. The icon becomes a meeting place, an existential encounter, a window through which we look on the saints not as shadowy figures from a remote past but as contemporary brothers and sisters in Christ, members of the same household of God. We feel free to call on them through prayer for family support as they intercede to God in our behalf. For example, St. Basil writes, "I accept the saintly apostles, prophets, and martyrs, and in my prayer to God I call upon them and through their prayer I receive mercy from our God who loves all humanity" (Epistle to Amphilochios). There is in man an innate sense of reverence for moral greatness. In Orthodox Christianity this reverence finds expression in the veneration of the Saints, the moral giants of our faith. The Orthodox believer's daily association with the saints, whose lives glorified Christ, serves to form the Orthodox lifestyle. The veneration of saints serves also as a safeguard of the truth faith and as a test of Orthodoxy. Any teaching that is not in harmony with the lives and faith of the saints is rejected as false. All that is in harmony is welcomed for the enrichment it brings.

4.3 "HAVING REMEMBERED ALL THE SAINTS"

Thus, we do not pray alone during the liturgy. We pray together with all the saints. This is expressed when the priest says, "Having remembered all the saints, again and again, in peace let us pray to the Lord." The saints here refer to both the living and departed members of the Church. More than once during the liturgy the deacon calls on us to pray with the similar exhortation: "Calling to remembrance our most

holy, pure, blessed and glorified Lady, Theotokos and ever-Virgin Mary together with all the saints, let us commit ourselves and one another and our whole life to Christ our God." Here we see clearly that the purpose of bringing to mind the Theotokos and all the saints is to lead us to a deeper commitment "to Christ our God". The focus is not on the saints but on Christ. After we have remembered the saints, we move on "to commit ourselves and each other and our whole life to Christ our God". Having fixed our gaze on others in the family of God who have rendered perfect service to His excellent glory, we are properly inspired to offer ourselves in total surrender and commitment to Christ our Lord.

4.5 RELICS OF SAINTS

The veneration of the relics of saints dates back to the early church. According to the Orthodox belief the body remains a Temple of the Holy Spirit even after death. Redeemed, cleansed, sanctified by the blood of Jesus, consecrated by the indwelling Spirit, the bodies of saints are drenched, as it were, to their very bones with divinity. St. Cyril of Jerusalem (4th century) writes: Though the soul is not present, a power resides in the bodies of the saints because of the righteous soul which has for so many years dwelt in it, or used it as its minister (Catechetical Lectures SVIII, 16). Bp. Kallistos Ware reminds us that the veneration of the relics of saints in the Orthodox Church proceeds from a highly developed theology of the body: Belief in the deification of the body and in its eventual resurrection helps to explain the Orthodox veneration of relics. Since the body is redeemed and sanctified along with the soul, and since the body will rise again, it is only fitting that Christians should show respect for the bodily remains of the saints. Reverence

for relics is not the fruit of ignorance and superstition, but springs from a highly developed theology of the body.

We read in The Martyrdom of Polycarp: So we later took up his bones, more precious than costly stones and more valuable than gold, and laid them away in a suitable place. There the Lord will permit us, so far as possible, to gather together in joy and gladness to celebrate the day of his martyrdom as a birthday, in memory of those athletes who have gone before, and to train and make ready those who are to come hereafter.

CHAPTER FIVE

5. INTERCESSION OF SAINTS

5.1 Intercession of the Saints is merely a prayer on our behalf:

The bible supports this kind of intercession: "pray one for another" (James 5:16). Even the Saints requested others to pray for them. St. Paul asks the Thessalonians: "pray for us" (2Thes 3:1). The same he asks of the Hebrews (Heb 13:18), and of the Ephesians "Praying always with all prayer and supplication for all the saints; and for me, that utterance may be given unto me" (Eph 6:18). Similar requests for prayer are innumerable in the Bible. Now, if the Saints request our prayers, shouldn't we request theirs? And if we ask others to pray for us who are still striving, in this life and are "subject to like passions as we are", shouldn't we rather ask for the prayers of those who finished their course and are living in Paradise with Christ? Have they lost their favor after departing from earth to Paradise? or is

it only lawful to ask for their prayers here on earth but not where thy are so close to Christ in Paradise? And if we request men to pray for us, shouldn't we rather ask the Angels to pray for us?

5.2 God often requested the intercession of the righteous on behalf of other people:

God often asked for, approved, and allowed this to happen. We shall give some examples for intercessions that God accepted:

a-The story of the Patriarch Abraham and King Abimelech: Abimelech sinned in taking Sarah (Abraham's wife) unto his household, but he did this in "the integrity of his heart" for Abraham said of her that she is his sister. Now the Lord came to Abimelech in a dream and warned him that he would surely die. Then the Lord said unto him: "Now therefore restore the man his wife; for he is a prophet, and he shall pray for thee, and thou shalt live." (Gen 20: 1-7) The Lord could have forgiven him as soon as he restored the woman to her husband, but He added the condition that Abraham pray for him that he may live. Here we see an example of God asking specifically for the intercession of Abraham on behalf of Abimelech.

b- The story of Job the righteous, and his three friends (Job 42): In a similar manner the Lord requested Job's intercession and prayer on behalf of his three friends, as a condition for forgiving them. The Bible records this as follows: "The Lord said to Eliphaz the Temanite, My wrath is kindled against thee and against thy two friends... Therefore take unto you now seven bullocks and seven rams, and go to my servant Job, and offer up for yourselves a burnt offering; and

my servant Job shall pray for you: for him will I accept; lest I deal with you after your folly" (Job 42: 7-8). In both incidents, God Himself addresses a person, and yet declines to grant the forgiveness of a sin unless a particular Saint prays on behalf of that person. God does so in order to exalt his Saints and honor them before people, and He accepts, even requests such intercession.

c-The intercession of Abraham on behalf of Sodom: The Lord could have inflicted His punishment on the city of Sodom without involving the Patriarch Abraham in this affair. And Abraham did not intervene of his own initiative. It was the Lord Who discussed the matter with Abraham and thus gave him a chance to intercede on behalf of those people, and accepted his intercession. The Lord saw fit that this incident should be recorded in the Bible that He may exalt Abraham before the whole world, and demonstrate to us to what extent He honors His Saints. The Bible records this as follows: "And the Lord said, Shall I hide from Abraham that thing which I do ?!" (Gen 18:17)... And the Lord discussed the matter with Abraham, and gave him a chance to intercede on behalf of the city in case there were 50, or 45, or 40, or 30, or 20, or even 10 righteous people in the city, that the Lord may spare the city for their sake. This does not only serve to demonstrate the favor that Abraham has with God, but also the favor that all the righteous have with God, seeing that God would have spared a whole city for their sakes. "And the Lord said, If I find fifty righteous within the city, then I will spare all the place for their sakes"."I will not do it for the forty's sake". "I will not destroy it for twenty's sake", "I will not destroy it for ten's sake". (Gen 18:26-32). The use of the words "for the sake of..." is

Theo- logically significant, since it exemplifies God's saving of certain people for the sake of others. It gives a clear indication of the intercession of the righteous on behalf of the sinners, and of God's approval of such intercession, even before such intercession is invoked or offered.

d- The intercession of Moses on behalf of the people of Israel: God condemned the people of Israel to destruction because of the golden calf. Nevertheless, He did not execute His Judgment immediately, but rather discussed the matter with the Prophet Moses, thus offering him a chance to intercede on their behalf, and indeed, accepted his intercession. And as Abraham addressed the Lord saying: "That be far from Thee to do after this manner", Moses say's to Him: "Turn from Thy fierce wrath, and repent of this evil against Thy people. Remember Abraham, Isaac, and Israel Thy servants, to whom Thou swarest."

The Bible tells us after this "And the Lord repented of the evil which He thought to do unto His people." (Ex 32: 7-14) So-far, we have cited examples of the prayer of the living on behalf of the living. Those who departed, have even more favor with God, so much so, that God spared people for their sakes even without their prayers. How much more would He, had they prayed for someone: As an example we cite God's acts of mercy and compassion for the sake of His servant David. On account of King Solomon's sin, God decided to divide his kingdom, however, God tells him concerning this matter: "Notwithstanding in thy days I will not do it for David thy father's sake: but I will rend it out of the hand of thy son. Howbeit I will not rend away all the kingdom; but will give one tribe to thy son for David my servant's sake." (1Kings 11:12,13). God repeats the same

account when He speaks with Jeroboam: "behold I will rend the kingdom out of the hand of Solomon...but he shall have one tribe for my servant David's sake..." (1Kings 11:31,32). "I will not take the whole kingdom out of his hand: but I will make him prince all the days of his life for David my servant's sake."(1Kings 11:34). God repeats the same expression "for David my servant's sake" 3 times in the same chapter. On account of this the psalmist pleads with God saying: "For Thy servant David's sake turn not away the face of thine anointed." (Ps 132:10). If such is the favor that David has with God, how much more would be the favor that the Virgin and the Angels have? and the favor of John the Baptist (greatest ever born of a woman)? And how much would be the favor of the martyrs who suffered and died for His sake? And since we find no fault in asking for the prayers of our fellows on earth, why shouldn't we ask for the prayers of those who "shine as the brightness of the firmament" (Dan 12:3). And why shouldn't we ask for the prayers of those who. fought the good fight, finished the course, kept the faith..(II Ti 4:7). And if intercession (which is actually prayer on our behalf) is considered an advocacy, and as such is unacceptable, then the prayers offered by any person on behalf of another would also be an unsolicited advocacy, since we have only one advocate! And if this is so, then the Apostle must have erred (God forbid), when he said: "pray one for another" (Jas 5:16), since the relation between God and man is a direct one, and -in view of the Divine love- needs nobody else's prayer! It follows also, that all the prayers on behalf of others that are mentioned in the Bible are meaningless and contrary to Divine love!! (according to them), since God loves His children and does not need others to pray on their behalf to remind Him of His parental

care and love for them! And then we will be at a loss when we try to explain God's purpose when He asked for Abraham's prayers on behalf of Abimelech and of Job's prayers on behalf of his friends. Prayers of people (whether departed or striving) for others is a proof of the mutual love that exists between them. It is a proof of the faith of those living that those departed are alive and that their prayers are acceptable before God. It is a proof of the honor that God bestows upon His saints. It is for the benefit of mankind that God allowed this form of intercession. It constitutes a bridge between the inhabitants of heaven and earth.

5.3 A question often asked by those who don't believe in intercession:

Do Angels and saints know our affairs on earth and can they receive our prayers? The answer is an emphatic yes for the following reasons:

1- There is no doubt that the knowledge of those in heaven is far more than that of those on earth. Saint Paul tells us: "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known." (1Co 13:12). This means that our knowledge will increase as we reach the "other world" and many mysteries will be revealed to us once we shed this carnal body that restrains the spirit. There and then our knowledge shall increase and we shall depart from the circle of "knowledge in part" to a much wider circle of knowledge.
2- Angels know our affairs on earth as is evident from the Lord's saying: "there is joy in the presence of the angels of God over one sinner that repenteth"

(Luke 15:10). The affairs of those on earth are thus known to the heavenly be they Angels or spirits of the righteous. They know those who repent and they rejoice for their repentance for how can they rejoice if they don't know?

3-Angels know our prayers because they carry our prayers to the throne of God. The evidence for this is abundant especially in the book of revelation where we are told that the prayers of the saints are offered before God from the hands of the Angel and from his censer.(Rev 8:3-5) The same can be said of the "four and twenty elders" (priests) in Rev 5:8 "having every one of them.. golden vials full of odours which are the prayers of the saints." This is evidence of their knowledge of our prayers which they offer to God. The same can be said of our Guardian Angel "Take heed that ye despise not one of these little ones; for I say unto you that in heaven their angels do always behold the face of my Father which is in heaven." (Mat 18:10)

4. Another example is the story of the rich man and Lazarus in Luke 16:25, where Abraham tells the rich man: "Son, remember that thou in thy lifetime receivedst thy good things, and likewise Lazarus evil things." How did our father Abraham know about the lives of both Lazarus and the rich man? Again when the rich man asks Abraham to send Lazarus to his five brothers to "testify unto them lest they also come to this place of torment" Abraham answers: "They have Moses and the prophets" (Luke 16:28,29). How could Abraham have known about Moses and the prophets knowing that he departed from earth hundreds of years before the birth of Moses and the other prophets? Obviously he knew about all these things. How could he not

know when the Lord says of him: "Your father Abraham rejoiced to see my day:and he saw it, and was glad." (Jn 8:56).

5.4 THE TESTIMONY OF THE SPIRITS OF THE MARTYRS:

Saint John tells us in the book of Revelations: "I saw under the altar the souls of them that were slain for the word of God and for the testimony which they held. And they cried with a loud voice, saying, How long O Lord, Holy and true, dost Thou not judge and avenge our blood on them that dwell on earth? And white robes were given unto every one of them, and it was said unto them, that they should rest yet for a little season, until their fellow-servants also and their brethren, that should be killed as they were, should be fulfilled." (Rev 6:9-11). You see, those martyrs knew after their death, that the Lord had not yet avenged them, and they cry unto God: How long willt Thou suffer that iniquity be victorious on earth? And how long willt Thou suffer that the strong in the flesh destroy thy children? And how long will they continue shedding their blood? How could those martyrs know about these things? They knew indeed, and when their "fellow-servants shall be fulfilled" they will know.

5.5 Another amazing incident involving Elijah the prophet is recorded in 2Ch 21. The story is told of King Jehoram who slew all his children, made high places (for the worship of idols), and wrought that which was evil in the eyes of the Lord." And there came a writing to him from Elijah the prophet saying thus saith the Lord. because thou hast not walked in the ways of Jehoshaphat thy father....behold, with a great plague will the Lord smite thy people and thy

children." This, in spite of the fact that Elijah was taken up to heaven several years earlier! How could this happen? and how did Elijah know after his departure from earth? and how did he manage to send this message?.

5.6 The departed saints live, the Lord explains this to the Sadducees: "have ye not read that which was spoken unto you by God saying: I am the God of Abraham and the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob. God is not a God of the dead, but of the living." (Mat 22:31,32). Those saints are living, so why consider them dead by not asking for their prayers? Both Moses and Elijah appeared with the Lord on Mount Tabor during the Transfiguration. Moses who died in the flesh 14 centuries earlier, was seen with the Lord alive same like Elijah who was taken up to heaven. The spirits of the righteous are immortal, they are in paradise, where they see and know more than we do Let us now consider some biblical examples of the intercession of the Angels: The book of Zechariah tells us of an Angel interceding on behalf of Jerusalem, "Then the angel of the Lord answered and said: O Lord of hosts, how long willt Thou not have mercy on Jerusalem..." his intercession was indeed accepted by the Lord "thus saith the Lord: I am returned to Jerusalem with mercies, my house shall be built in it saith the Lord of hosts" (Zech 1:12-16). Another example is the Angel interceding on behalf of Joshua the high priest, when Satan was standing to resist him, we hear the Angel say "The Lord rebuke thee, O Satan...is not this a brand plucked out of fire?" The intercession of the Angel was indeed accepted for we are told concerning Joshua: "Take away the filthy garments from him. And unto him he said, behold I have caused thy iniquity to pass from thee.." (Zech 3:1-4). We are

also told of Israel when he blessed the two children of Joseph his son that he said: "The Angel which redeemed me from all evil, bless the lads." (Gen 48:16). Angels are described in the epistle to the Hebrews as "ministering spirits, sent forth to minister for them who shall be heirs of salvation." (Heb 1:14). If they have a ministry on behalf of people here on earth, how much more would be their ministry on our behalf in heaven where they belong? Let us finally answer another objection that is put forward: Some say that we should not "pray to the saints" only to God. Indeed! for in asking for their help we are not praying to the saints but actually asking them to pray on our behalf. We ask for the saints intercession because of the great favor they have with God. We ask for their intercession because God allowed and accepted such intercessions. We believe in intercession because we believe in the life of the world to come. Because we believe that the saints who departed are alive. We ask for the intercession of the Saints to honor them for God himself honors them by accepting their intercessions. "If any man serve me, him will my Father honor." (Jn 12:26). We believe in intercession because we believe in the unity of the body of Christ (the church) we are all members of the one body whether we are here on earth or there in heaven. We intercede for them by praying for those who departed, and they intercede for us, and this exemplifies the true unity of the body of Christ. By believing in intercession we practice humility, deeming ourselves needy for the prayers of those saints who have pleased God.

CHAPTER SIX

6. WHAT DO THE EARLY CHURCH SCHOLARS WRITERS SAID REGARDING PRAYER TO SAINTS?

Considering that the Church consistently fought many heresies, and most of the writings we have from the very early centuries deals with correcting heresies, it certainly seems that if there was an outcry against prayer to saints we would have some record of it. Instead, nothing I can find.

Various (probably Philo and Agathopus who were with Ignatius): [After the death of Ignatius and in a dream] some of us saw the blessed Ignatius suddenly standing by us and embracing us, while others beheld him again praying for us, and others still saw him dropping with sweat, as if he had just come from his great labour, and standing by the Lord." (Martyrdom of Ignatius [A.D. 107 – 116])

6.1 Hippolytus of Rome:

[Speaking of the three youths in the fire in Daniel] "Tell me, you three boys, remember me, I entreat you, that I also may obtain the same lot of martyrdom with you…" (Commentary on Daniel, 30.1 [A.D. 202-211]

6.2 Clement of Alexandria

"In this way is he [the true Christian] always pure for prayer. He also prays in the society of angels, as being already of angelic rank, and he is never out of their holy keeping; and though he pray alone, he has the choir of the saints standing with him [in prayer]" (Miscellanies 7:12 [A.D. 208]).

6.3 Cyprian of Carthage

"Let us remember one another in concord and unanimity. Let us on both sides [of death] always pray for one another. Let us relieve burdens and afflictions by mutual love, that if one of us, by the swiftness of divine condescension, shall go hence first, our love may continue in the presence of the Lord, and our prayers for our brethren and sisters not cease in the presence of the Father's mercy" (Letters 56[60]:5 [A.D. 253]).

6.4 Cyril of Jerusalem

"Then [during the Eucharistic prayer] we make mention also of those who have already fallen asleep: first, the patriarchs, prophets, apostles, and martyrs,that through their prayers and supplications God would receive our petition. (Catechetical Lectures 23:9 [A.D. 350]).

I'm including Cyril in the list even though he is out of the ante-Nicene period (but not by much) because he is clearly stating the theological position on prayer to the saints, and because this is still the same practice you'll find in the Orthodox Church today. It's a two-fer!

There isn't a huge list of writings on the subject to really pound the subject home, but there's some good ones (plus Cyril). It appears that prayer of the saints doesn't get a lot of air time either for or against in the early writings, but as I said before, this just demonstrates to me that the practice was never a controversy, so there was never an outcry. There's plenty of evidence that the practice is present early on, and no indication that the practice was ever resisted.

I will say that most places where I find prayer in the early writings it is referring to petitioning God, as is right. As I'll mention below, this is in line with actual Orthodox practice where the vast majority of prayer is directed to God. Some object that the quotes above don't specifically say that someone asked the saints to pray for them. I think that is quibbling over trivialities and I don't see that it affects the conversation at all. Those people will only be satisfied if every single writer spells out the entirety of the Orthodox understanding of prayer with the saints in detail. I'm afraid we can't go back in time and get their thoughts that specifically.

Up to the reformation the practice was normative in the church as far as I can tell, only being opposed by a couple heretical groups (not heretics because of this practice but because of other views, such as the world being created by the Devil), in the 10th and 12th century.

6.5 Gregory of Nazianus said of his deceased father: "I am well assured that his intercession is of more avail now than was his instruction in former days, since he is closer to God, now that he has shaken off his bodily fetters, and freed his mind from the clay which obscured it and

6.6 Jerome wrote: "If the Apostles and Martyrs, while still in the body, can pray for others, at a time when they must still be anxious for themselves, how much more after their crowns, victories, and triumphs are won!

6.7 EPHRAIM THE SYRIAN

"You victorious martyrs who endured torments gladly for the sake of the God and Savior, you who have boldness of speech toward the Lord himself, you

saints, intercede for us who are timid and sinful men, full of sloth, that the grace of Christ may come upon us, and enlighten the hearts of all of us so that we may love him" (*Commentary on Mark* [A.D. 370]).

"Remember me, you heirs of God, you brethren of Christ; supplicate the Savior earnestly for me, that I may be freed through Christ from him that fights against me day by day" (*The Fear at the End of Life* [A.D. 370]).

6.8 THE LITURGY OF ST. BASIL

"By the command of your only-begotten Son we communicate with the memory of your saints . . . by whose prayers and supplications have mercy upon us all, and deliver us for the sake of your holy name" (*Liturgy of St. Basil* [A.D. 373]).

6.9 GREGORY OF NAZIANZ

"May you [Cyprian] look down from above propitiously upon us, and guide our word and life; and shepherd this sacred flock . . . gladden the Holy Trinity, before which you stand" (*Orations* 17[24] [A.D. 380]).

"Yes, I am well assured that [my father's] intercession is of more avail now than was his instruction in former days, since he is closer to God, now that he has shaken off his bodily fetters, and freed his mind from the clay that obscured it, and holds conversation naked with the nakedness of the prime and purest mind . . . " (ibid., 18:4).

6.10 GREGORY OF NYSSA

"[Ephraim], you who are standing at the divine altar [in heaven] . . . bear us all in remembrance, petitioning for us the remission of sins, and the fruition of an everlasting kingdom" (*Sermon on Ephraim the Syrian* [A.D. 380]).

6.11 JOHN CHRYSOSTOM

"He that wears the purple [i.e., a royal man] . . . stands begging of the saints to be his patrons with God, and he that wears a diadem begs the tentmaker [Paul] and the fisherman [Peter] as patrons, even though they be dead" (*Homilies on Second Corinthians* 26 [A.D. 392]

When you perceive that God is chastening you, fly not to his enemies. but to his friends, the martyrs, the saints, and those who were pleasing to him, and who have great power [in God]" (*Orations* 8:6 [A.D. 396]).

6.12 AMBROSE OF MILAN

"May Peter, who wept so efficaciously for himself, weep for us and turn towards us Christ's benign countenance" (*The Six Days Work* 5:25:90 [A.D. 393])

6.13JEROME

"You say in your book that while we live we are able to pray for each other, but afterwards when we have died, the prayer of no person for another can be heard. But if the apostles and martyrs while still in the body can pray for others, at a time when they ought still be solicitous about themselves, how much more will

they do so after their crowns, victories, and triumphs?" (*Against Vigilantius* 6 [A.D. 406].

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